

III Scenarios First

A discovery session: participants wrestle with real situations, write their own commandments, and only then meet the ten.

AUDIENCE

Teens (middle school and up). Adults joining as participants can use the same questions as written.

GROUP SIZE

Nine to forty participants, working in huddles of three to five.

ROOM

Any room where small groups can huddle and talk. No wall space or special setup needed; this is the format for the room you actually got.

STAFFING

One facilitator, plus roughly one circulating staff member or assistant per fifteen participants, moving between huddles.

Materials

- ☐ Scenario cards, cut apart
- ☐ Blank paper or index cards and pens, for each huddle to draft its own commandment
- ☐ Camper handouts, one per person or per pair, **held back until the reveal** (segment 4)
- ☐ Participant feedback slips (60 and 90 minute versions)

Timing

This program can be adapted based on time available.

Segment	45 min	60 min	90 min
1. Welcome and framing	5	5	10
2. Scenario huddles: what would you do?	10	15	20
3. Write your own commandment	5	5	10
4. The reveal: meet the ten	5	5	10
5. Share-back and matching	10	15	20
6. Full-group discussion	10	10	10
7. Research moment	–	5	5
8. Closing and feedback	–	–	5
Total	45	60	90

Pick your column and follow it top to bottom; each column adds up on its own. Segments 7 and 8 are fully written out below, so nothing new is needed to run the longer versions.

Running the Session

1. Welcome and Framing (5/5/10 min)

Welcome everyone, but do not explain the ten commandments yet. The whole point of this format is that participants build their own ethics first and meet the document second. Frame it with the tradition's own version of that move:

SUGGESTED FRAMING

When Israel received the Torah at Sinai, the people answered with a famous phrase: **נַעֲשֶׂה וְנִשְׁמָע**, *na'aseh v'nishma*, "we will do and we will hear" (Exodus 24:7). Doing first, understanding after. Tonight we are working the same way: you will start with real situations and your real instincts, and only afterward see what Jewish tradition has to say about them.

2. Scenario Huddles: What Would You Do? (10/15/20 min)

Break into huddles of three to five. There are ten scenario cards, so keep it to ten huddles or fewer; if your group is large enough to need more, two huddles can work the same scenario. Each huddle receives one scenario card, a blank card, and a pen. No handouts yet. Each huddle discusses:

Huddle Questions

1. What is really going on in this scenario? Who is affected, including people who are not in the room when it happens?
2. What would you actually do? Be honest, not aspirational.
3. What would the best version of you do?

CHOOSING CARDS

Any cards work, but if you want a spread, mix the people-focused scenarios (The Screenshot, The Rumor, The Pile-On) with the AI-focused ones (The AI Essay, The Deepfake, The AI Companion). Keep unused cards in reserve for huddles that finish early.

3. Write Your Own Commandment (5/5/10 min)

Now each huddle writes one commandment: a single sentence that, if everyone followed it, would prevent their scenario or repair it. Push them past "don't be mean" toward something a real person could follow on a real night. Have them write it big and clear on the blank card.

KEEP THESE CARDS

The commandments participants write are some of the most valuable feedback this project gets. Collect them at the end (or photograph them) and send them in with your facilitator feedback form. A drafted commandment that does not match any of the official ten is a candidate for the next revision.

4. The Reveal: Meet the Ten (5/5/10 min)

Now hand out the camper handout and give everyone a few quiet minutes to skim all ten commandments. Each huddle then answers two questions: Which of the ten fits your scenario best? And how close is it to the commandment you wrote?

5. Share-Back and Matching (10/15/20 min)

Each huddle takes a turn: read your scenario in one sentence, read the commandment you wrote, then read the official commandment you matched it to. Ask each huddle: What did the tradition see that you did not? What did you see that the tradition did not?

FIELD NOTE

The matches are rarely one to one, and that is the good part. A huddle that wrote "don't share what isn't yours" for The Screenshot might match it to Honor and Protect Dignity, Protect Privacy, or Guard Your Tongue, and the argument about which one is the real learning.

6. Full-Group Discussion (10/10/10 min)

Open it up with whichever of these fits your group:

Discussion Prompts

- Between what you would actually do and what the best version of you would do: what makes the gap?
- Did any official commandment surprise you? Push back on it.
- Did we write anything tonight that the official ten is missing?
- Which commandment does our community most need right now?

7. Research Moment (–/5/5 min)

Take five minutes to mention the research and impact of these technologies. Participants consistently want to know more about what all this is doing to them, so tell them, and tell them where it comes from:

SUGGESTED SCRIPT

"Every commandment in this handout has a section called What Teens Are Saying. Those are not decorations; they are real studies of thousands of teens. A couple worth knowing: almost half of teens say social media has a negative impact on people their age, and teens themselves draw a line with AI: most say using it for research is fine, but fewer than one in five say the same about having it write your essay. The research is in your hands in this handout. Take it seriously; it is about you."

8. Closing and Feedback (–/–/5 min)

Hand out participant feedback slips and give everyone three quiet minutes to fill them out. Collect them before anyone leaves, along with the commandment cards the huddles wrote. Close with:

"In a place where there are no human beings, strive to be a human being." (*Pirkei Avot 2:5*) Online is often a place where it feels like there are no human beings. Strive to be one.

In the 45 and 60 minute versions, skip the written feedback for participants and instead fill out the facilitator feedback form yourself as soon as possible after the session, while it is fresh. Still collect the commandment cards.

Facilitation Notes

- **Guard the reveal.** This format only works if participants have not read the ten commandments before segment 4. If your group already knows the document well, choose a different Digital Mensches program format instead.

- **Honest before aspirational.** The "what would you actually do" question is where the real conversation lives. Do not rush huddles past it toward the right answer.
- **Depth over coverage.** One scenario per huddle is the design, not a compromise. Resist the urge to cycle more cards through.
- **Adults in the room.** If adults participate alongside teens, they use the same questions and answer for themselves, not about "kids these days."